From First Concern to a Shared Open-Issues List

A nine-step plan for your husband's care, with a line for who does each step and by when.

The goal: the family's concerns are written down with an example for each, a few have been talked through, and what is still open sits on one short list with a name beside each item.

There is no clock on this. Take the steps in order, over a few weeks if that suits the family. Put a name and a date next to each one, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask your husband, and each person in the family, to name their main concerns about how his care is going. One or two apiece is plenty.			
2. Write a real example for each concern: what happened, and on which day.			
3. Next to each concern, note what it is mostly about: the care itself, communication, paperwork or the workload.			
4. Write your own answer to one question: which tasks couldn't you keep doing the way you do them now?			
5. Where two people describe the same thing differently, write down both accounts. Don't pick one.			
6. Mark any concern that belongs with a professional, such as a question about his health for his doctor's office, and write it as a question.			
7. Choose which concerns to take to the next family conversation, a few and not all of them, and set a day for it.			
8. For each concern you talked about, agree on one next action and one person who will follow up. Before the conversation ends, agree how you'll say so when you want more support, and whom you'll tell.			
9. Start an open-issues list for everything that wasn't settled, and keep it where everyone can see it.			

You're done when

The family's concerns are written down, each with an example. The ones you've talked about have a next action and a name beside them, and the rest are on an open list. The family has also agreed how you, as the person doing most of the caring, will say so when you want more support, and whom you'll tell. What comes after that, a professional's look at the whole arrangement and any decision about your husband's care, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

If a step stalls

- If someone would rather not name a concern, write “nothing to add for now” beside their name and go on. The list stays open.
- If two people can't agree on what happened, the step hasn't failed. Both accounts go on the page, and step 5 is done.
- One family conversation isn't expected to settle everything. That is what step 9 is for.
- A question about your husband's health doesn't have to wait for the family conversation. It can go to his doctor's office whenever you're ready to ask it.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes the family's part. It doesn't say whether the arrangement is working, decide whether your husband needs more help or a different kind, or stand in for a professional's review. Finishing it doesn't certify anything about his care. It means the family's concerns are on paper.

Ready for the next step?

You have the steps in order and a list that stays open. The care interview goes through your husband's situation and the help around him area by area with you, so the concerns on your list sit inside the whole picture, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›